

Topic: The Pillars of Islam,

Sub Topic: Fasting.

Observances of Fasting

Q (a) Give description of the ways in which Fasting is Carried out among Muslims. [10]

Q (a) how do Muslims fast in the month of Ramadan? [10]

Q (a) Describe how Muslims observe the pillar of Fasting. [10]

CAIE Marking Scheme

In answer to this part of the question candidates could simply state facts like: Muslims have breakfast, sehri, before dawn. They abstain from food, drink etc. during daylight hours and that they break their fast at sunset. Answers could also include details like, Muslims state the formal intention to fast, they also abstain from smoking, taking medicines and marital relations during the fast and that they break their fast normally with a date and then offer their prayer. A good response however would focus on the need for Muslims to be particularly pious during their fast and to visit the mosque regularly and attend Tarawih prayers in the evening. Other examples of devoting themselves to prayer could be that on the night of power they should attend the mosque and spend the night in prayer. The able candidates could raise the point that during the fast Muslims should live their life as normal, making no concessions for lack of food or drink.

Structure of Answer

Para 1	Para 2	Para 3
☐ Introduction. ☐ Reference. ☐ Suhoor (Morning Meal) ☐ Fajr Prayer and other practices.	☐ Day time dos and don'ts. ☐ Regularity for Prayers. ☐ Other practices. ☐ Before sunset.	☐ Iftar. ☐ Tarawih. ☐ The Night of Power.

Answer

- ☐ A fundamental practice in all major religions.
- ☐ Declared obligatory in 2nd A.H.
 -  "The month of Ramadhan in which was revealed the Qur'an, a guidance for the people and clear proofs of guidance and criterion. So whoever sights the month, let him fast it..." [02:185]
- ☐ It is a great source of self-realization, self-control and righteousness.
- ☐ Muslims observe the month of Ramadan with full zeal and zest.
- ☐ **Sehri:** They start their day with breakfast (Suhoor) which is a healthy practice both spiritually and medically. Prophet (PBUH) said:
 -  "Eat Suhoor as there is blessing in it."
- ☐ **Intention:**
 -  "I intend to keep the fast for tomorrow in the month of Ramadan"
- ☐ **Fajr Prayer and blessed practices like recitation of Quran, Tasbeehat etc.**
- ☐ They must avoid **Food, drink, medicine or any nourishment.**
- ☐ It should not only be taken as **diet control practice.** One must learn to **harness their negative energy.**
- ☐ They must train themselves to avoid **sins and evil actions.**
- ☐ **Regularity for Prayer** and other **routines** of study/job etc.
- ☐ They then offer **Zohr** Prayer and involve in **recitation** of **Quran**, different **Tasbeehat** and other **Nafil Prayers** and then offer **Asr**. It is recommended to spend time in recitation of Quran and **invocation** some minutes before **sunset** as it is blessed and significant time.
- ☐ **Iftar:** Then they **break** their **fast** upon sunset reciting this dua:
 -  "O Allah! I fasted for You and I believe in You and I put my trust in You and I break my fast with Your sustenance"
 Following **Sunnah method** of breaking fast is recommended as Prophet (PBUH) would break his fast with water, date or salt sometimes.
- ☐ It is recommended to invite and accept others' **invitations** over Ramadan meals in order to **promote brotherhood** and love.
- ☐ After performance of Maghreb and Isha Prayers Muslims offer Tarawih Prayer. Tarawih Prayer is also a great practice



of Islam which is performed enthusiastically with full zeal and zest. Big number of memorizers of Quran lead Tarawih Prayer in every Mosque in every corner of the world even some set up at their homes as they lead Tarawih to people who gather at their place. There are organizations/individuals that establish the system of Tarawih with translation and Tafsir. 3 Rak'ats of **Witar** are **offered** in **congregation** after performance of Tarawih.

- ☐ Nights are supposed to be spent in worships.
- ☐ Especially **odd nights** of last **10 days** of Ramadan are of special importance in Muslims as they stay in Mosque/home for **Aitkaf** and worship Allah whole night in order to attain the virtues of **Laila-tul-Qadar**. (The Night of Power)
 - 📖 "The Night of Destiny is better than a thousand months" [97:03]
- ☐ Some Muslims calculate their Zakat payment annum in a way that they pay their yearly Charity in Ramadan to get multiplied rewards. At the end of Ramadan Muslims celebrate Eid-ul-Fitr and pay Sadaqa-tul-Fitr.

Benefits of Fasting

Q (a) What are the moral spiritual and other benefits of Fasting in Ramadan? [10]

Structure of Answer

Para 1	Para 2	Para 3
☐ General Intro.	☐ Moral Benefits. ☐ Spiritual Benefits.	☐ Social Benefits. ☐ Medical Benefits. ☐ Financial/Economic Benefits.

Answer

- ☐ The literal meaning of **Sawm** is 'to abstain' or 'to abandon'. Islamic Shariah defines it to restrain from food, drink and all evils.
- ☐ Fasting (Sawm) is one of the Pillars of Islam. It became obligatory in 2nd A.H.
 - 📖 "Oh you who believe! Fasting is prescribed to you as it was prescribed to those before you, that you may learn piety and righteousness" [2:183]
- ☐ Like other practices Fasting also has uncountable Moral, Spiritual, Physical, Economic and Social benefits for Individual Muslims and Collectively as Ummah.
- ☐ **Self-control.**
 - 📖 Hadith: "The strong person is not the good wrestler. Rather, the strong person is the one who controls himself when he is angry" [Bukhari]
- ☐ **Prepares for real life challenges.**
- ☐ **Allah's blessings.**
 - 📖 In another Hadith Prophet (PBUH) Said: "The month of Ramadan is the month of endurance and the reward for endurance is paradise. It is a month whose beginning is mercy; whose middle is forgiveness and whose end is freedom from hell"
- ☐ Fasting develops **empathy** and **compassion** which make us realize the pain and sufferings of poor and downtrodden people of our society.
- ☐ Spiritually it brings us closer to Allah. Fasting has been declared as Shield against sins in a Hadith Qudsi:
 - 📖 "Fasting is a shield (Protection from sins)."
- ☐ **Realization** of Allah's blessings.
- ☐ Starvation and its related diseases cause one person per minute to die on this planet, 75% of them being infants and children under the age of 5. Fasting saves food and if adopted as regular practice can solve food shortage crisis.
- ☐ It is quoted from the Prophet of Islam to have said:
 - 📖 "Fast, you'll be healthy"
- ☐ An Egyptian pyramid inscription in 3800B.C also reads:
 - 📖 "Humans live on one-quarter of what they eat; on the three-quarters live their doctor!"
- ☐ The three fathers of Western Medicine; (Hippocrates, Galen & Paracelsus) prescribed fasting as the greatest remedy and the physician within. Life Magazine in its September 1996 issue considered fasting: the healing revolution. There are more than 500 medical journal articles available on therapeutic fasting on the internet.
- ☐ Ramadan brings a **Season of Good Deeds** as people are motivated to do more good deeds as compared to other



normal day lives.

- ☐ People spend handsome bucks in charity and this ensures circulation of wealth.
- ☐ However, fasting is not only being hungry and thirsty for hours. It's a complete Philosophy which has long term effects in shaping a successful individual life as well as forming a healthy and productive society. Allah SWT says in a Hadith Qudsi: "Fasting is for me and I will give its reward"

Q (b) Explain how fasting strengthens or keep the Islamic community together. [04]

Q (b) 'Fasting ties Muslim community in one bond.' Discuss. [04]

Points to be covered

- ☐ Fasting makes Rich Muslims realize the pain and suffering of poor members of the society and motivate them to support and help them.
- ☐ It teaches Muslims community to control and harness their negative energy and control over their anger and other emotions.
- ☐ Zakat is usually given in this month that ensures circulation of wealth and affects national economy.
- ☐ The social gatherings promote brotherhood, love and happiness in the society.

People that are exempted from Fasting

Q (b) Outline the kinds of Muslims who are excused from fasting during this month. [04] [J/2007]

Points to be Covered

<u>People Who are exempted</u>	<u>Reason</u>
Suffering from life sickness	Fasting will worsen their condition
Above age or Below Age	It's beyond their Physical Capacity
Abnormal or Unconscious	They don't have that sense.
Women who are pregnant or with new born babies.	They can't bear/they have to feed the child.
Travelers	They can't bear the hardship
 Ref: [Fasting for] a limited number of days. So, whoever among you is ill or on a journey [during them] - then an equal number of days [are to be made up]. And upon those who are able [to fast, but with hardship] - a ransom [as substitute] of feeding a poor person [each day] ..." [02:184]	

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